

Search authors

The best way to search for authors is to use the `search` query parameter, which searches the `display_name` and the `display_name_alternatives` fields. Example:

- Get works with the author name "Carl Sagan":

<https://api.openalex.org/authors?search=carl sagan> ↗

Searching without a middle initial returns names with *and* without middle initials. So a search for "John Smith" will also return "John W. Smith".

Names with diacritics are flexible as well. So a search for David Tarrago can return David Tarragó, and a search for David Tarragó can return David Tarrago. When searching with a diacritic, diacritic versions of the names are prioritized in order to honor the original form of the author's name. Read more about our handling of diacritics [here](#) ↗.

 You can read more in the [search page](#) in the API Guide. It will show you how relevance score is calculated, how words are stemmed to improve search results, and how to do complex boolean searches.

Search a specific field

You can also use search as a [filter](#), by appending `.search` to the end of the property you are filtering for:

- Get authors with the name "john smith" in the `display_name`:

https://api.openalex.org/authors?filter=display_name.search:john smith ↗

When searching for authors, there is no difference when using the `search` parameter or the filter `display_name.search`, since `display_name` is the only field searched when finding authors.

Search filter

Field that is searched

`display_name.search``display_name`

You can also use the filter `default.search`, which works the same as using the `search` parameter.

Autocomplete authors

You can autocomplete authors to create a very fast type-ahead style search function:

- Autocomplete authors with "ronald sw" in the display name:

<https://api.openalex.org/autocomplete/authors?q=ronald sw> ➤

This returns a list of authors with their last known affiliated institution as the hint:

```
{
  "results": [
    {
      "id": "https://openalex.org/A5007433649",
      "display_name": "Ronald Swanstrom",
      "hint": "University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, USA",
      "cited_by_count": 19142,
      "works_count": 339,
      "entity_type": "author",
      "external_id": "https://orcid.org/0000-0001-7777-0773",
      "filter_key": "authorships.author.id"
    },
    ...
  ]
}
```

 Read more about [autocomplete](#).